Film & Cinematography

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Shot grammar

Establishing shot establishing shot, the exterior of a roadside diner at night, warm windows glowing, a neon sign on the roof, small figures visible inside

Master shot wide master shot of the whole scene, both people at the booth in frame, the room around them visible

Single clean single, medium close-up of one person alone in the frame, looking just off camera at someone unseen

Over-the-shoulder over-the-shoulder shot, the back of one person's head soft and dark in the foreground, the other person facing camera in sharp focus

50/50 shot 50/50 profile two-shot, two people facing each other in profile across a table, each taking half the frame

Shot / reverse shot shot / reverse shot coverage, matching over-the-shoulder angles on each person, same lens and height

Reaction shot reaction shot, a silent close-up of the listener's face as the news lands, eyebrows lifting, lips parted

Insert insert shot, a hand sliding a folded note and a brass key across a diner table, no faces

Cutaway cutaway to the wall clock above the counter, its second hand ticking, between shots of the conversation

POV shot point-of-view shot from her seat in the booth, looking at the diner door as a dark figure in a hat steps in

Italian shot extreme close-up "Italian shot" of a gunslinger's squinting eyes filling a 2.39:1 frame, sweat and stubble, harsh sun

180-degree rule coverage that respects the 180-degree rule: every angle on the same side of the line between the two people, so their screen positions never flip

Crossing the line deliberately cross the 180-degree line between shots so the two people suddenly face the same direction on screen, creating unease

30-degree rule cut between angles at least 30 degrees apart, or change the shot size, so cuts between shots of the same subject never look like a jump

Screen direction keep screen direction consistent: the traveler moves left to right in every shot of the journey

Eyeline match matched eyelines across the cut: she looks down and to the right from the balcony, he looks up and to the left from the street

Look room framed with generous look room: the face on the left third of the frame, gazing right into open space

Cut on action cut on action: a wide shot of her pushing the diner door, cut mid-movement to a close-up of her hand on the handle

Cheating cheat both actors' angles toward camera so their faces read clearly while they still seem to face each other

Staging & signature shots

Deep staging deep staging with deep focus: a face in the near foreground, a figure in the middle of the room, a child visible through the far window, all sharp

Doorway frame framed through a dark doorway, a lone figure silhouetted against a bright desert landscape outside

Planimetric staging planimetric staging: camera square to the back wall, three people standing side by side facing the lens, flat frontal composition, centered

One-point perspective one-point perspective down a long symmetrical hotel corridor, all lines converging to the center, a small figure at the far end

Walk and talk walk-and-talk: two colleagues stride toward the camera down a busy office corridor mid-conversation, the camera backing up ahead of them on a Steadicam

Split diopter split diopter shot: a face in extreme foreground on the left and a figure far in the background on the right, both in sharp focus, a faint soft seam between them

Mirror shot mirror shot: a man stares into a bathroom mirror, his reflection sharp and lit, the real back of his head dark and soft in the foreground

Shadow play expressionist shadow play: the elongated shadow of a clawed figure climbing a staircase wall, one hard low light, no person visible

Top shot top shot looking straight down at four people around a round card table, tops of heads, scattered chips and cards, hard overhead lamp

Triangle staging triangle staging, a three-way standoff in a dusty circular plaza, two figures in the near corners, one far in the middle, all facing inward

Trunk shot trunk shot: extreme low angle from inside a car trunk, two men in suits looking down into the lens, bright sky behind them, the dark trunk lid framing the top

The Spielberg face the Spielberg face: slow push-in on a child's upturned face, eyes wide, mouth slightly open in awe, lit by a warm glow from something off screen

The Kubrick stare the Kubrick stare: a man tilts his head down and glares up into the lens from under his brow, a faint unsettling smile, symmetrical framing

Double dolly Spike Lee double-dolly shot: a man glides forward without walking, standing still on the moving dolly, the night street sliding past behind him

Low-angle hero 360 low-angle hero 360: the camera circles low around a team of heroes rising to their feet, sun flaring behind them, slow motion

Pillow shot Ozu-style pillow shot: an empty tatami room at low height, a teapot on a low table, paper screens glowing with afternoon light, no people

SnorriCam SnorriCam shot: the camera rigged to his chest facing his sweating, panicked face, which stays locked in frame while the street lurches and tilts behind him

Overhead insert overhead insert shot, straight down on a mustard-yellow suitcase being packed with neatly arranged books, binoculars and a portable record player, two small hands, symmetrical

Monumental scale monumental scale: a tiny lone figure at the foot of a colossal brutalist monolith rising into thick orange haze, minimal composition

Hand through the grass a hand brushing the tops of tall wheat at magic hour, the low sun flaring directly behind it, golden backlight, floating handheld camera

Editing

Cross-cutting cross-cut between the hero sprinting through the rain and the train bearing down, alternating shots that get shorter and closer

Parallel editing parallel editing between a young father in 1917 in sepia and his grown son in the present day in color, the scenes echoing each other

Kuleshov effect Kuleshov-style edit: hold on a neutral, unreadable face, then cut to the thing he sees, letting the cut supply the emotion

Axial cut axial cut: two abrupt cut-ins straight down the lens axis, from a wide shot of a man in a field to a medium shot to a close-up

Elliptical edit elliptical edit: she shuts her front door, then cut straight to her arriving at the empty beach, skipping the journey

Long take one continuous long take with no cuts: the camera follows them in through the kitchen, along the corridor and out into the crowded club

Split screen split screen: the left half shows her on the phone in a pink bedroom, the right half shows him on the phone in a blue office, the two halves divided by a clean line

Freeze frame freeze frame on the boy's face as he turns to look straight into the camera on the beach, the image stops, grainy black and white

Montage sequence montage sequence over an upbeat song: dawn runs, the calendar filling up, the sweat, and finally arms raised at the top of the steps

Soviet montage Soviet montage on a great stone staircase: a crowd fleeing, a line of soldiers' boots marching down, a baby carriage rolling loose, stark black and white, hard rhythmic cuts

Hip-hop montage hip-hop montage: rapid-fire extreme close-ups, each a few frames long, of a key in a lock, coffee pouring, a match striking and a pupil dilating, each hit with a sharp sound

Graphic match cut graphic match cut: a bone tossed into a blue sky spins at the top of its arc and becomes a long white satellite drifting in black space in the same position

Jump cut jump cuts in a single fixed framing of a hotel room: she sits on the bed, then lies across it, then stands at the window, time skipping between each cut

Flashback flashback: push in on her face as she remembers, slow dissolve to a warm, faded, grainy image of her as a child on a summer lawn

Nonlinear timeline tell it as a nonlinear timeline: open on the aftermath, then jump back to the morning, then to a week earlier, with chapter title cards

Light & color

Motivated lighting motivated lighting: soft daylight from a tall window on the right falls across her face, the side away from the window falls into shadow, no other visible source

Practicals lit by practicals in frame: a green banker's lamp on the bar, a red neon beer sign and a string of bulbs, warm pools of light in a dark room

Venetian-blind noir film noir: hard light through venetian blinds casting diagonal bars of shadow across a detective's face and the wall, cigarette smoke, high-contrast black and white

Top light Gordon Willis top light: one soft source directly overhead, a man at a desk with his eyes lost in shadow, warm amber, underexposed and dark

Day for night day-for-night: a rider crossing a desert under hard sun, graded deep blue and underexposed to read as moonlit night, crisp shadows

Available light only available light only: a trapper in a snowy forest at dusk, lit by the cold blue sky and a small campfire, wide lens close to his face, no film lights

Candlelight lit only by candlelight: two figures in 18th-century dress at a card table, warm golden glow on their faces, rich darkness beyond, soft and grainy

Volumetric haze volumetric haze in a cavernous warehouse: hard shafts of sunlight slant down from high windows through smoke, a lone silhouette standing in one beam

Screen glow lit only by the cold blue flicker of a television in a dark living room, a man alone on a sofa, the rest of the room black

Red and blue strobes night, red and blue police strobes washing across her face from opposite sides, wet street reflections, a sense of sudden trouble

Three-strip Technicolor three-strip Technicolor look: hyper-saturated primaries, a ruby-red dress against emerald green and a deep blue sky, lustrous 1950s Hollywood color

Two-strip Technicolor two-strip Technicolor look: only coral reds and sea greens, no true blues, skies rendered teal, soft 1920s glow

Matrix green Matrix-green grade: a man in a long black coat and sunglasses in an office corridor, everything tinted a cold digital green, high contrast

Amélie grade storybook grade in the spirit of Amélie: saturated emerald greens and cherry reds, blues pulled out, warm golden skin, a whimsical Paris café

Fincher yellow-green Fincher-style grade: desaturated, a sickly yellow-green cast, inky shadows, a rain-damp office at night lit by fluorescent tubes

Hot yellow filter hot yellow tobacco-filter grade over a dusty border-town street at noon, blown-out sky, heavy heat haze

Desaturated war grade desaturated war-film grade, color drained almost to grey, crushed blacks, soldiers in a smoky landing with hard contrast and a newsreel feel

Color isolation black-and-white film with color isolation: a crowded wartime street in monochrome, one little girl in a red coat the only color in the frame

Neon magenta and blue neon noir lighting: a face split between hot magenta and electric blue neon, deep glossy blacks, synth-scored stillness

Modern black and white pristine modern digital black and white, a wide deep-focus shot of a family on a beach, silvery tones, enormous detail, no grain

Sepia to color a sepia-toned farmhouse doorway swinging open onto a world of saturated Technicolor flowers and a yellow road

Formats & aspect ratios

1.33:1 (4:3) 4:3 aspect ratio (1.33:1), a boxy almost-square frame, pillarboxed

1.37:1 Academy 1.37:1 Academy ratio, classical boxy framing

1.19:1 Movietone 1.19:1 near-square frame, claustrophobic, early-sound-film proportions

1.66:1 European widescreen 1.66:1 European widescreen framing

1.85:1 flat 1.85:1 widescreen frame

2.39:1 scope 2.39:1 anamorphic widescreen, letterboxed, wide cinematic frame

2.76:1 Ultra Panavision 70 2.76:1 Ultra Panavision 70, an extremely wide strip of a frame, epic horizon

1.43:1 IMAX 1.43:1 IMAX frame, towering vertical scale, immense detail

9:16 vertical vertical 9:16 framing for a phone, a single figure filling the height of the frame

Changing aspect ratio change the aspect ratio between eras: boxy 1.37:1 for the past, widening to 2.39:1 for the present

65mm / 70mm film shot on 65mm film: crisp large-format detail, extremely fine grain, rich deep color, vast landscape

35mm film shot on 35mm film: fine organic grain, soft highlight roll-off, warm natural skin tones

16mm film shot on Super 16mm film: visible chunky grain, muted color, intimate handheld feel

Super 8 Super 8 home movie: heavy grain, warm faded color, light leaks, soft focus, rounded flickering frame edges

VHS camcorder VHS camcorder footage: soft smeared color bleeding sideways, scan lines, a band of tracking noise, a blocky date stamp in the corner

Early digital video early 2000s MiniDV digital video: harsh over-sharpened detail, blown-out white sky, smeary motion, 4:3 standard definition

Anamorphic lens shot on anamorphic lenses: oval vertical bokeh, a long horizontal blue streak flare across the frame, 2.39:1, slight edge distortion

Silent-era film silent-era film: flickering scratched black and white, sped-up 18 frames per second motion, iris vignette, 1.33:1, an intertitle card

Digital cinema camera shot on an ARRI Alexa: clean grainless digital image, wide dynamic range holding the sunset and the shadows, natural skin tones

Found footage found-footage horror: shaky handheld night-vision camcorder, green monochrome, a figure with glowing eyes at the end of a hallway, REC indicator and timestamp

Security camera CCTV security camera footage: high corner angle looking down a convenience store, fisheye distortion, grey low-saturation image, timestamp and CAM 03 overlay

Genres & movements

Film noir classic 1940s film noir: a man in a fedora and trench coat under a lone streetlight on a rain-slicked street, hard high-contrast black and white, long shadows

Neo-noir neo-noir: a lone driver in a parked car on a rain-soaked Los Angeles street at night, magenta and cyan neon reflected in the wet asphalt, sodium-orange streetlights

Western classic western: a lone rider on horseback crossing a vast desert valley beneath towering red mesas, hard afternoon sun, dust, extreme wide shot

Science fiction hard science fiction: a small spacecraft drifting past an enormous ringed gas giant, cold sunlight, deep black space, realistic scale

Horror horror: a terrified woman in the foreground of a dark hallway, unaware of a pale figure standing motionless in the doorway far behind her, cold moonlight

Folk horror folk horror in bright midsummer daylight: villagers in white with flower crowns dancing around a maypole in a meadow, eerie smiling calm, overexposed pastel

Musical movie musical: a dancer mid-twirl in a yellow dress on a hilltop at magic hour, a painted purple sky, a single spotlight following her

Heist heist film: a crew of five in sharp dark suits walking toward the camera in a line, slow motion, low angle, a casino glowing behind them

Romantic comedy romantic comedy: a couple sharing a red umbrella on a rainy autumn street in New York, warm shop windows glowing, soft flattering light, a meet-cute

War film war film: soldiers silhouetted in a muddy trench at night, a flare burning orange overhead through drifting smoke, desaturated palette

Road movie road movie: a dusty convertible on a long empty desert highway under a huge sky, a lone motel sign in the distance, late afternoon sun

Kaiju kaiju film: a colossal monster silhouette rising out of the bay behind a city skyline at night, searchlights sweeping through smoke, crowds fleeing in the foreground, shot from street level

Wuxia wuxia: two swordfighters in flowing robes balanced on the swaying tops of a misty bamboo forest, green light filtering through, weightless and graceful

Period drama period drama: a young woman in a Regency empire-waist dress walks across a misty meadow at dawn toward a grand English country house, soft overcast light

German Expressionism German Expressionist film: a gaunt figure creeping through a crooked painted alley, jagged angled walls, shadows painted onto the set, black and white with a tinted wash

Italian Neorealism Italian Neorealism: a father and young son walk a bicycle down a crowded postwar Roman street, real locations, natural light, black and white

French New Wave French New Wave: a cool young couple strolling down a Paris boulevard in 1960, she sells newspapers in a striped shirt, handheld camera, natural light, black and white

New Hollywood New Hollywood 1970s look: a grimy Manhattan street at dusk, yellow cabs and steam from a manhole, grainy warm film stock, long telephoto lens, a loner in an army jacket

Dogme 95 Dogme 95 style: shaky handheld digital video of a tense family dinner in a real dining room, available light only, no music, awkward intimate framing

Giallo giallo: a black-leather-gloved hand reaching for a doorknob in a stylish apartment lit with saturated red and blue gels, operatic suspense

Hong Kong action Hong Kong heroic-bloodshed gunfight: a man in a white suit leaps sideways in slow motion with a pistol in each hand, white doves bursting through a candlelit church

Slow cinema slow cinema: a static wide shot held for minutes of a lone figure crossing a misty, wind-blown plain toward a distant farmhouse, muted grey light

Mumblecore mumblecore: two twenty-somethings talking awkwardly in a cramped real apartment kitchen at night, flat practical light, handheld digital, improvised feel

Kitchen-sink realism British kitchen-sink realism: a young man in a donkey jacket on a wet street of brick terraced houses with smoking chimneys, overcast industrial town, gritty black and white

Directors & cinematographers

Alfred Hitchcock in the spirit of Alfred Hitchcock: a man in a grey suit running across a flat empty prairie as a crop-duster plane swoops low behind him, wide controlled framing, suspense

Stanley Kubrick in the spirit of Stanley Kubrick: a perfectly symmetrical one-point-perspective hotel corridor with patterned carpet, two identical girls in pale blue dresses standing at the far end, wide lens, unsettling stillness

Akira Kurosawa in the spirit of Akira Kurosawa: samurai with banners charging through driving rain and mud, telephoto compression, wind-whipped flags, black and white

Yasujirō Ozu in the spirit of Yasujirō Ozu: a static low camera at tatami height, an elderly couple seated on the floor of a Japanese home framed by sliding doors, calm, frontal, gentle

Andrei Tarkovsky in the spirit of Andrei Tarkovsky: a wooden house burning in a misty meadow, a lone figure standing in the wet grass watching, muted green-grey palette, a slow minutes-long take

Steven Spielberg in the spirit of Steven Spielberg: a kid on a bicycle silhouetted against a giant full moon over a forest, soft blue night, a sense of wonder

Martin Scorsese in the spirit of Martin Scorsese: slow-motion entrance into a crowded bar bathed in red light, a tough guy in a sharp suit, a rock song on the soundtrack, the camera gliding with him

David Lynch in the spirit of David Lynch: a room of red velvet curtains with a black-and-white zigzag floor, a single art-deco lamp, a figure standing very still, uncanny dream logic

David Fincher in the spirit of David Fincher: two detectives with flashlights entering a pitch-dark apartment, beams cutting through dust, desaturated yellow-green, locked-off precise framing, rain outside

Christopher Nolan in the spirit of Christopher Nolan: a city street folding up and over itself into the sky, two figures in suits standing in the middle, steel-blue grade, IMAX large-format scale

Denis Villeneuve in the spirit of Denis Villeneuve: a colossal dark oval vessel hovering silently over a misty green valley, tiny figures on the ridge below, muted palette, monumental stillness

Terrence Malick in the spirit of Terrence Malick: looking up into the canopy of a huge oak at magic hour, the sun flaring through the leaves, a mother lifting a child, floating wide-angle camera

Quentin Tarantino in the spirit of Quentin Tarantino: a woman in a yellow tracksuit with a katana standing in a snowy Japanese garden lit deep blue, stylized grindhouse composition, a chapter title card

Wong Kar-wai in the spirit of Wong Kar-wai: a woman in a patterned qipao passing a man in a narrow green corridor under a warm lamp, slow motion, rain on the window, saturated longing

Wes Anderson in the spirit of Wes Anderson: a perfectly symmetrical pink-and-red hotel lobby, a lobby boy in a purple uniform standing dead center facing the camera, pastel palette, flat frontal composition

Sofia Coppola in the spirit of Sofia Coppola: a young woman in a pink sweater sitting on a hotel windowsill looking out over Tokyo at dusk, soft pastel light, quiet loneliness

Bong Joon-ho in the spirit of Bong Joon-ho: a family running down an endless stone staircase through a hillside city in torrential night rain, water cascading past them, framed to show high and low

Spike Lee in the spirit of Spike Lee: a Dutch-angle close-up of a man on a Brooklyn stoop talking straight into the lens on the hottest day of the summer, saturated red and orange heat

Jordan Peele in the spirit of Jordan Peele: a man floating and falling slowly through an endless black void, a small glowing screen of the real world far above him, uncanny social-horror stillness

Agnès Varda in the spirit of Agnès Varda: a row of old mirrors standing upright on a sunny beach, each reflecting a slice of sea and sky, playful and personal, bright natural light

Roger Deakins lit like Roger Deakins: two figures fighting in pure silhouette against a vast glowing blue digital billboard in a dark skyscraper at night, single source, minimal

Emmanuel Lubezki shot like Emmanuel Lubezki: an ultra-wide lens inches from a man's face as his breath fogs in the cold blue dusk of a vast forest, natural light only, one floating continuous take

Vittorio Storaro lit like Vittorio Storaro: helicopters silhouetted over a jungle through billowing orange smoke at sunset, saturated symbolic color, operatic

Gordon Willis shot like Gordon Willis: a couple on a bench beneath the Queensboro Bridge at dawn, silvery widescreen black and white, silhouettes against the river

Hoyte van Hoytema shot like Hoyte van Hoytema on IMAX film: a tiny astronaut standing in shallow water on an endless ocean planet as a mountainous wave rises on the horizon, natural light, tall large-format frame

Janusz Kamiński lit like Janusz Kamiński: silhouetted figures in a smoky room against windows blown out to pure white, heavy backlit haze, desaturated bleach-bypass color

Bradford Young shot like Bradford Young: a woman's face emerging softly out of deep warm darkness, lit by a dim window to the side, underexposed, rich luminous skin, most of the frame in shadow

Greig Fraser shot like Greig Fraser: a caped silhouette in heavy rain lit only by a red emergency flare, thick haze, soft detuned lens, dark textured image

Sven Nykvist lit like Sven Nykvist: two women's faces close together in the frame, one in profile and one facing the camera, soft natural northern light, minimal grey background, black and white

James Laxton shot like James Laxton: a young man on a beach at night looking straight into the lens, his dark skin glowing in saturated blue and violet moonlight, teal ocean behind, intimate and lush